

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 488

By Faison

A RESOLUTION to recognize and honor the Great Smoky Mountains National Park.

WHEREAS, Tennessee is proud to be home to the Great Smoky Mountains National Park, which spans across the border into North Carolina to include 522,427 acres of pristine landscape in the heart of the Appalachian Mountains; and

WHEREAS, replete with breathtaking mountain peaks, sprawling lush green forests, gorgeous cascading waterfalls, scenic trails, hikes, drives, and so much more, the Great Smoky Mountains National Park is one of the most celebrated parks in the United States; and

WHEREAS, the park boasts many fascinating fauna, including black bear, white-tailed deer, elk, chipmunk, nineteen firefly species, over 200 species of birds, and more than thirty species of salamander, earning the park the designation of "salamander capital of the world"; and

WHEREAS, the Great Smoky Mountains National Park employs approximately 200 permanent staff and 140 seasonal workers and engages more than 2,000 volunteers annually; the park further supports 33,748 jobs in the surrounding communities and has a total economic impact of over \$2.2 billion annually; and

WHEREAS, with thirteen million recreational visits in 2023 alone, the Great Smoky Mountains National Park is the most visited National Park in the country, with visitation totaling more than that of Yosemite, Yellowstone, and Grand Canyon national parks combined; and

WHEREAS, the park was designated an International Biosphere Reserve on October 26, 1976, and a World Heritage Site on December 6, 1983; and

WHEREAS, although its grandeur and environmental, economic, and cultural importance are now quite evident, the Great Smoky Mountains National Park might not exist,

had it not been for the efforts of conscientious, prescient Tennesseans of the early twentieth century; and

WHEREAS, after a failed attempt by the North Carolina legislature to preserve the Smoky Mountain area in the 1890s, Tennesseans David Chapman, Ann Davis, Ben Morton, and Paul Fink took up the mantle of preservation in the 1920s; and

WHEREAS, in the late 1920s, the legislatures of Tennessee and North Carolina appropriated \$2 million each for land purchases, with Tennessee passing Senate Bill 781 in 1927 to allocate its funding for the endeavor; and

WHEREAS, additional money was raised by individuals, private groups, and even school children, who pledged their pennies, and by 1928, a total of \$5 million had been raised; the Laura Spelman Rockefeller Memorial Fund matched this amount, resulting in a total of \$10 million and assuring the purchase of the remaining land; and

WHEREAS, as a result of these efforts, and with official dedication as a National Park by President Franklin D. Roosevelt in 1940, Tennesseans, North Carolinians, and visitors from the world over continue to enjoy the verdant haven that is the Great Smoky Mountains National Park; and

WHEREAS, the park is an enduring symbol of the rich history of our State, and it is most fitting that we pause to reflect on its important legacy and continued impact at this time; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we recognize and honor the Great Smoky Mountains National Park, a true Tennessee treasure and a gift from our forebears that we will continue to protect and cherish.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to

the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.